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Attitudes Towards the High Achiever: The Fall of the Tall Poppy

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Three studies are reported that concern attitudes towards a person in a high position (the tall poppy) and towards the tall poppy's fall. The studies were developed in relation to theoretical analyses concerned with value systems, envy, social comparison, and other psychological processes. In Study 1, 531 students in South Australian high schools responded to scenarios in which either a high achiever or an average achiever experienced failure. Results showed that subjects reported feeling more pleased about a high achiever's fall than about an average achiever's fall, more pleased when a high achiever fell to the average position on the performance scale rather than to the bottom, and more pleased and friendly towards a high achiever who fell to the average position than towards an average achiever who fell to the bottom. In Study 2, 361 university students responded to scenarios in which a high achiever or an average achiever cheated at an examination. Results showed that the students were more punitive towards the high achiever who transgressed than towards the average achiever and more pleased about the high achiever's fall. In Study 3, 205 adult subjects completed a Tall Poppy Scale, an extended version of the Rokeach Value Survey, the Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale, and a measure of political preference. Results for a global measure of tall poppy attitudes indicated that negative attitudes were more likely to occur among subjects who were low in global self-esteem, who assigned less importance to values concerned with achievement and social power, and who were more to the left in their political preference.

What kinds of attitudes do people hold towards the person who occupies a very high position in some field of endeavour and how do they react when such a person suffers failure and falls from the top of the ladder? My interest in this topic was stimulated by the observation commonly made within my culture that Australians like to see those in high positions experience a fall from grace, as when an important politician is caught out in a foolish act, when a well-known business leader loses a lot of money in a stock market crash, or when a much-publicised personality in the TV industry suffers a sudden decline in popularity. These people are called "tall poppies" and it is claimed that Australians feel a certain amount of satisfaction when tall poppies are cut down to size and suffer a major reverse in status.[1]

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However, the significance of this topic goes beyond national concerns. A lot has been written about the achievement motive and the personality characteristics of people who have done well at their chosen pursuits (e.g., Atkinson & Feather, 1966; McClelland, 1985; Spence, 1983) but there is a relatively sparse psychological literature on how others regard the person in a high position, whether this status be achieved or ascribed. In this article I describe three studies that investigated attitudes towards the high achiever and the fall of the tall poppy. The first two studies involved experimental manipulations and they were concerned with high achievers; the third study was correlational in nature and investigated attitudes towards tall poppies as conceived more generally.

Ambivalent Attitudes

Let us first clear some theoretical ground. We can make a start by recognising that attitudes towards tall poppies are often mixed or ambivalent and that affective reactions following the fall of a tall poppy may reflect these initial mixed feelings. The tall poppy may be admired but also envied, respected but also distrusted, a popular figure but also one who is vulnerable to public criticism. When a tall poppy falls there may be a certain amount of sympathy but also some degree of satisfaction in observing the discomfiture of a person who has fallen from a high pedestal.

It is not too difficult to account for the initial positive attitudes and the subsequent feelings of sympathy when the tall poppy falls, especially for those tall poppies who have earned their high status after battling against difficult odds or because of special talents that few others possess. Most Western societies value competence, individualistic enterprise, and accomplishment, though in varying degrees (Feather, 1975, 1986; Hofstede, 1980; McClelland, 1985; Rokeach, 1973). These cultural values, instilled through socialisation, influence our attitudes so that the consistently high achiever is seen in a more positive light in some respects when compared with the person whose performance is average. For example, the high achiever will probably be regarded as more competent, hard-working, efficient, confident, and as deserving of more respect and admiration than the average performer in societies that value individualism and achievement. These positive attitudes are translated into feelings of regret and sympathy when such a person falls.

That is not to say, however, that the high achiever is uniformly seen in a positive light or is always well-liked. Evaluation takes different forms and can involve more than one dimension. Helmreich, Aronson, and Le Fan (1970) noted that competence does not inexorably lead to liking and cited evidence to support their claim (e.g., Bales, 1958; Hollander & Webb, 1955; Radloff & Helmreich, 1968), and theorists concerned with interpersonal attraction have argued for the multidimensionality of the attraction construct, suggesting that a distinction should be made between affection and admiration (Berscheid & Walster, 1978; Heider, 1958; Rubin, 1973). In a similar vein, Lydon, Jamieson, and Zanna (1988) recently distinguished between two important dimensions of similarity that influence impression formation: attitude similarity (Byrne, 1971) and activity preference similarity (Werner & Parmelee, 1979). They argued that, in the absence of other information, attitude similarity may convey to the perceiver that the other person is worthy of respect and possesses intellectual traits, while activity preference similarity activates a set of inferences along the social dimension that concern how much one likes the other person and wants to engage in social interaction. Consistent with these discussions is the fact that we do not necessarily

choose as our friends those whom we admire and respect. At a greater extreme, it is also possible for individuals to hold negative stereotypes about high achievers that conflict with positive evaluations. For example, they may tend to see high achievers generally as distant, unsociable, unscrupulous and overly competitive.

All of these discussions imply that attitudes towards high achievers vary along different dimensions and that they can also be ambivalent, involving a mixture of positive and negative feelings, though these feelings may not necessarily be equally balanced. However, they do not take us very far in explaining why negative attitudes towards high achievers exist and why people feel some satisfaction at seeing a tall poppy fall. There are a number of theoretical approaches that can be used to address these questions and they vary in their degree of conceptual elaboration. One can appeal to general treatments of the nature of envy (e.g., de la Mora, 1987; Foster, 1972; Sabini & Silver, 1982; Schoeck, 1969), to relative deprivation theory (e.g., Cook, Crosby, & Hennigan, 1977; Crosby & Gonzales-Intal, 1984; Walker & Pettigrew, 1984), to social comparison theory (e.g., Bers & Rodin, 1984; Goethals & Darley, 1977; Salovey & Rodin, 1984; Tesser, 1986), to the analysis of personal and cultural values (e.g., Feather, 1975, 1986; Rokeach, 1973), to discussions of the effects of pratfalls or blunders (e.g., Helmreich et al., 1970), to just-world theory (e.g., Lerner, 1980; Lerner & Lerner, 1981), to theoretical analyses that are concerned with attitudes towards status and authority (e.g., Adorno, Frenkel-Brunswik, Levinson, & Sanford, 1950; Rokeach, 1960; Sanford, 1973; Wilson, 1973), to attributional analyses that take account of the different causes of high achievement and relations between these causes and affective attitudes towards the high achiever (e.g., Weiner, 1986), and to the analysis of self-esteem and self-interest as related to the fulfilment or frustration of personal motives.

It is unlikely that all of these approaches are equally applicable to explaining behaviours in all instances where tall poppies fall. We are dealing with a situation that involves many different variables. Tall poppies can differ in many respects (e.g., in personality characteristics, in how they attained their position, and in the field in which they are eminent). Those who react to their fall can also vary in many ways (e.g., in their values, attitudes, and self-esteem). And the fall itself can take different forms depending, for example, on whether it is a minor or major fall or was the fault of the tall poppy or an accident. Because of this range of variation, some theoretical approaches are probably more applicable to certain contexts than others and a global approach to understanding how people react to the fall of tall poppies is likely to be unattainable.

In the three studies that follow I draw upon different theoretical ideas that were used to guide each specific inquiry. The studies, however, form a coherent package and they may be seen as opening up a new field of investigation.

Study 1

The first study was concerned with the fall of tall poppies who had earned their high position by virtue of consistent high performance in the past, that is, with high achievers. The hypotheses were based upon a consideration of general values, especially as related to Australian society. I assumed that values that stress collectivism rather than achievement or status are probably antithetical to respect for a tall poppy who stands above others. Collectivist values within a culture may also underlie feelings of satisfaction when a tall poppy falls, especially when the fall takes the tall poppy to an average position and makes the tall poppy

more similar or equal to others. In contrast, the fall of an average achiever would be welcomed less because the fall removes the person from the collectivity that is identified with the middle range of accomplishment. Some of these effects would be countered by individualist, achievement values.

Observers of Australian society provide some evidence for a tension between collectivist and achievement values. They comment on the conflict between a collectivist ideology that values mateship, equality, and group solidarity and a competitive social system that values status differences and independent achievement (Feather, 1975, 1985, 1986). They also refer to an anti-intellectual bias that is assumed to be ingrained within the Australian culture. For example, back in 1930, the historian Hancock noted that a crucial assumption of Australian society was a "fair and reasonable" standard of living for everyone, accompanied by a distrust for special excellence and a dislike of authority and status seekers. Equalitarianism went hand in hand with anti-intellectualism. Hancock's metaphor of nearly 60 years ago still has a grain of truth in it when he wrote that Australian democracy "is properly anxious that everybody should run a fair race. It is improperly resentful if anybody runs a fast race. Indeed, it dislikes altogether the idea of a race, for in a race victory is to the strong. Its solicitude is for the weak, and its instinct is to make merit take a place in the queue" (p. 183).

The roots of these values lie in the historical development and emergence of the new Australian nation with its Anglo-Celtic origins. There have been major social and economic changes in Australia since Hancock's statement but the tension between equality and achievement still persists. Although success is valued, there is also the belief that one should not be too different from others, too successful in whatever pursuit one has chosen, or too far above the average. I may be overstating the case. There is a degree of subjectivity in these comments but there is also evidence for them from historical, sociological, and psychological analyses of the Australian culture.

Acknowledgement of the effects of collectivist values is also implicit in the way Helmreich et al. (1970) interpreted findings from their study on the effects of a pratfall or foolish mistake made by a competent stimulus person. Helmreich et al. showed that attraction for a competent stimulus person was greater than for an incompetent counterpart. A foolish mistake made by the superior person (clumsily spilling a cup of coffee) enhanced his attractiveness among subjects who were average in self-esteem while subjects who were either high or low in self-esteem were more attracted to the competent stimulus person when he did not blunder. The foolish mistake had no significant effect on liking for the incompetent stimulus person for any of the self-esteem groups.

Helmreich et al. explained the increased liking for the competent stimulus person as probably due to the humanising of the competent individual. The foolish mistake made him closer and more similar to the person who was average in self-esteem and therefore more approachable. According to Helmreich et al., subjects high in self-esteem may have seen the competent stimulus person as similar in status to themselves and would therefore be more contemptuous of this person when he made the foolish mistake. Subjects low in self-esteem may have liked the competent person less when he made the blunder because they needed a perfect hero to respect and could not tolerate any imperfections.

This interpretation, like the preceding analysis of Australian cultural values, also demonstrates an awareness of possible tensions between collectivist and achievement values. The Helmreich et al. findings suggest that individuals may feel somewhat more satisfied when a fall makes a very competent person more

like themselves and in that sense more part of the human collectivity. The findings also imply that these effects may be a function of a person's level of self-esteem.

Attitudes towards a high achiever and towards his or her fall may also be related to judgements about the causes of the high achiever's success and failure. One would expect observers to attribute the performance of a consistently high achiever more to ability and effort when compared with attributions for the performance of an average achiever. These attributions would link up with values that concern competence and achievement and would thereby generate positive affect toward the high achiever, provided individualistic competence values were deemed to be important (Feather, 1988). However, if the high status occurred by way of ascription (e.g., inherited wealth) rather than by personal achievement, attitudes towards the tall poppy may be different, again depending in part on underlying value systems. In this case competence values may be less relevant and other values (e.g., those relating to respect for authority) would probably have more influence on positive attitudes toward the high status person. In both cases, however, collectivist values that emphasise affiliation and equality would undermine positive attitudes towards the tall poppy.

The manner in which observers react to the fall of a tall poppy may also be related to how they explain the fall. When the fall is seen as due to laziness or insufficient effort, observers may be more likely to react negatively, claiming that the tall poppy deserved to fall. The tall poppy may be seen as less deserving of failure when the failure can be attributed to external causes. Again, however, these reactions would depend in part upon underlying value systems that help to shape attitudes.

The argument that I have developed so far implies that observers will have mixed or ambivalent attitudes towards high achievers that relate to cultural and personal values and that reactions to the fall of high achievers will also reflect these values. However, one would also expect to find individual differences in the attitudes that people hold towards high achievers. Some individuals may hero worship a high achiever using the high achiever as a basis for identification. Others may be less positive in their attitudes. Some individuals may also have positive attitudes towards an average achiever while others may be less positive in their attitudes. These differences in initial attitudes would be expected to relate to how individuals react to the fall. Stronger initial attraction to a person should be accompanied by more regret and disappointment when a fall occurs.

On the basis of the preceding discussion I formulated the following hypotheses:

1. Subjects will express mixed or ambivalent attitudes towards a consistently high achiever that differ from those towards an average achiever.
2. Subjects will be relatively more pleased about a high achiever's failure than about an average achiever's failure.
3. Subjects will be relatively more pleased about a high achiever's failure when the high achiever falls to the middle or average level of the performance scale than to the bottom of the scale.
4. Subjects who are more attracted to a performer (high or average) will be less pleased about the performer's fall than subjects who are less attracted to a performer.

These hypotheses were tested in Study 1. In order to enhance the generality of the findings I included both male and female subjects in the study and I also varied the gender of the high and average achievers who suffered the fall. When reporting the findings, however, I will not highlight gender differences. There were very few of them and discussion of them is tangential to the main concerns of the study.

Method

Subjects

Five hundred and thirty-one subjects participated in the study (290 males, 238 females, 3 who did not indicate their gender). These subjects were drawn from five high schools in metropolitan Adelaide, South Australia, and they were tested in 1987. All were in Year 11 classes, the penultimate grade before completing high school. Mean age was 15.99 (SD = .71).

Overview of Procedure

Subjects completed a questionnaire during one of their regular class periods. Each questionnaire presented subjects with a scenario that described either a high or average achiever. Subsequently, the high or average performer was described as suffering a fall. There were six different forms of the questionnaire derived from the 2 x 3 combination of the gender of the stimulus person (John, Anne) described in the scenario that was presented to subjects and three types of fall (from high to middle, from high to low, from middle to low). The six forms of the questionnaire were randomly distributed to subjects in approximately equal numbers.

The design of the study is presented in Table 1. Note that the blank cell in Table 1 cannot be filled in this design because the average achiever cannot fall further than to the bottom of the scale and that fall (from middle to bottom) is classified as a medium fall rather than as a large fall. Note also that the top, middle, and bottom of the scale refer to a person's position relative to others and that the middle position on the performance scale corresponds to average performance, representative of the group as a whole.

Table 1 Design of Study 1

	Stimulus person	
Size of fall	High achiever	Average achiever
Large fall	Top to bottom	-
Medium fall	Top to middle	Middle to bottom

It could be argued that a more comprehensive design would include success conditions as well as failure conditions, would include low achievers as well as high and average achievers, and would allow for status maintenance as well as for status change. Such research would be worth conducting in the future but it was beyond the scope of the present inquiry. It should be noted, however, that there is no guarantee that the effects of success would be found to be opposite to or continuous with those of failure. The research literature shows that the effects of success and failure are often asymmetric rather than symmetric when affective and motivational variables are studied (e.g., Feather, 1982; Weiner, 1986). I decided to focus on the three cells in Table 1 because the three types of fall identified in these cells were the relevant ones in terms of the theoretical analysis that I have presented. The decision to use the top, average, and bottom positions in class performance as reference markers had considerable face validity for the high-school students who were tested and enabled me to investigate whether the average position would have an appeal in a culture where there is a tension between achievement and collectivist values.

Scenarios. Each scenario began by introducing a student who was either a high achiever or an average achiever. The description for the high achiever or tall poppy was as follows:

> John (Anne) is a new student who has joined a Year 11 class in a high school in Adelaide that is similar to most other Adelaide high schools. John (Anne) finds himself (herself) coming top of the class in the assessment/exams that are held in the first part of the year and he (she) continues to get higher marks than nearly every other student in his (her) class in the assessment/exams that follow throughout Year 11 and into Year 12.

The description for the average achiever was similar except that it indicated:

> John (Anne) finds himself (herself) near the middle of the class in the assessment/exams that are held in the first part of the year and he (she) continues to get marks that are generally average and similar to those obtained by a lot of others in his (her) class in the assessment/exams that follow throughout Year 11 and Year 12.

Causal attributions. Having read the description of the high achiever or the average achiever, subjects then completed five scales that related to possible causes of the high or average performance. The five scales had the following headings: (a) John (Anne) has a lot of natural ability; (b) John (Anne) worked hard; (c) the exams/assessment were very easy; (d) John (Anne) was just lucky; (e) John (Anne) got on well with the teachers. Each attribution scale was numbered from 1 to 7 with the following anchors: 1 = Not important at all as a cause, 7 = Extremely important as a cause. Subjects circled a number that best indicated how important they saw each reason as a cause of the stimulus person's consistently superior or generally average performance at school.

Semantic differential. To provide a personality description of the high and average achiever, subjects rated the stimulus person in the scenario they received on 26, 1-7 bipolar adjective scales. These scales were selected so as to sample a wide range of personality characteristics (e.g., boastful-shy, pleasant-unpleasant, efficient-inefficient, solitary-good mixer).

The ratings were correlated across the scales for all subjects and the matrix of intercorrelations was factor analysed using the principal factor solution with iterated communalities, followed by varimax rotation for the first four factors. The number of factors extracted was determined by using the scree test applied to the eigenvalues (Gorsuch, 1983). The four factors accounted for 36.5% of the variance. Three scales were constructed that were based on the first three rotated factors from this analysis, involving items with factor loadings greater than .30. The fourth factor was excluded because it was less easy to define than the other three and it was unstable from Study 1 to Study 2. The three scales were named positive qualities, introversion, and achievement orientation. The items in each scale were as follows (the adjective in italics indicates the direction in which the item was scored, scores from 1 to 7 being assigned after reversal of the scores for items with negative factor loadings):

Positive qualities. The scale consisted of eight items (the factor loadings for each item are presented in parentheses): unfriendly-*friendly* (.69), solitary-*good-mixer* (.65), unfair-*fair* (.53), unhelpful-*helpful* (.50), *sociable*-unsociable (-.49), *warm*-cold (-.47), unpleasant-*pleasant* (.44), and *attractive*-unattractive (-.44). Total scores for positive qualities could range from 8 to 56. The internal reliability of the scale (alpha) was .77.

Introversion. This scale consisted of six items: dishonest-*honest* (.58), hard-*soft* (.53), tough-*tender* (.48), *quiet*-pushy (-.48), boastful-*shy* (.48), and conceited-

bashful (.40). Total introversion scores could range from 6 to 42. The internal reliability of the scale (alpha) was .68.

Achievement orientation. This scale consisted of eight items: uncompetitive-*competitive* (.56), inferior-*superior* (.54), submissive-*dominant* (.54), lacks ambition-*ambitious* (.48), *wide interests*-narrow interests (-.37), self-effacing-*self-important* (.36), weak-*strong* (.33), and passive-*active* (.31). Total achievement orientation scores could range from 8 to 56. The internal reliability of the scale (alpha) was .69.

Attraction. Subjects then answered seven questions about the stimulus person in the scenario. The first five items asked subjects how happy they would be to go to a party with the stimulus person, to go to the movies with the stimulus person, to mix at school during recess and lunch time with the stimulus person, to play sport with the stimulus person, and to introduce the stimulus person to their friends. Subjects answered each question by using a 1-7 rating scale labelled "not at all happy" at the low end and "very happy" at the high end. The remaining two questions asked how much subjects thought they had in common with the stimulus person and how much they thought they would like the stimulus person. Subjects again answered each question by using a 1-7 rating scale. The anchors for the first question were "nothing in common" at the low end and "a lot in common" at the high end. The anchors for the second question were "dislike a lot" at the low end and "like a lot" at the high end.

A factor analysis involving the principal factor solution with iterated communalities indicated that a one-factor solution was appropriate. This single factor accounted for 58.2% of the variance. The respective factor loadings for the seven items were: .82, .83, .86, .64, .78, .58, and .80. The seven items were used to construct a scale called *attraction.* Total attraction scores could range from 7 to 49. The internal reliability (alpha) was .90.

The fall. Subjects were next presented with information that their stimulus person had suffered a fall in performance. The fall was described as occurring in the matriculation examination, the very important final public examination at high school that qualifies students to enter tertiary studies. This information took two forms, depending upon whether the stimulus person fell from the top to the middle of the performance scale or from either the top or the middle to the bottom of the performance scale.

The fall to the middle was described as follows:

> John (Anne) sits for the matriculation exam and ends up near the middle of his (her) class with a mark that is similar to the marks obtained by a lot of others in his (her) class.

The fall to the bottom was described as follows:

> John (Anne) sits for the matriculation exam and ends up near the bottom of his (her) class with a mark that is much lower than the marks obtained by most others in his (her) class.

Post-fall items. Subjects then answered a further set of questions about their stimulus person that related to his (her) fall.

The first question concerned whether the stimulus person deserved the mark that he (she) obtained in the matriculation examination. Subjects used a 1-7 rating scale with "John (Anne) didn't deserve what he (she) got" (coded 1) and "John (Anne) got what he (she) deserved" (coded 7) as the end labels. This variable is called *deserve to fall.*

Subjects then answered five questions about the possible causes of the lower score on the matriculation examination. These items were similar to the causal

attribution items previously described except that in this case the headings used were (a) John (Anne) lacks natural ability, (b) John (Anne) didn't work very hard, (c) the matriculation exam was difficult, (d) John (Anne) was just unlucky, (e) John (Anne) fell out with his (her) teachers. As before, subjects used 1-7 rating scales to record their answers with "not important at all as a cause" (coded 1) and "extremely important as a cause" (coded 7) as the end labels in each case.

The next item asked subjects whether they would feel privately rather pleased about the stimulus person's fall. They used a 1-7 rating scale to record their answers with "not pleased at all" (coded 1) and "very pleased" (coded 7) as the end labels. This variable is called *respondent satisfaction with fall.*

Subjects were then asked how they thought the stimulus person would feel about the fall. They used a 1-7 rating scale to record their answers, with "not pleased at all" (coded 1) and "very pleased" as the end labels. This variable is called *cue satisfaction with fall.*

The final item about the fall asked subjects whether they would feel more friendly to the stimulus person than before, less friendly to the stimulus person than before, or about the same as before, following the fall. They checked one of three answers: "more friendly than before," "about the same as before," or "less friendly than before" and responses to these items were coded 3, 2, or 1 respectively. This variable is called *more friendly attitude.*

Results

High versus average achiever. The set of variables assessed before the fall was analysed by using multivariate 2 x 2 x 2 analysis of variance (MANOVA) with gender of subject (male, female) as the first factor, gender of stimulus person (John, Anne) as the second factor, and achievement level (high, average) as the third factor in the analysis. The multivariate F was statistically significant for the main effect of achievement level, $F(9,428) = 21.93$, $p < .001$; and for the main effect of gender of subject, $F(9,428) = 2.23$, $p < .05$; but not for any of the other effects. Univariate 2 x 2 x 2 analyses of variance (ANOVAs) were then computed for each variable with the two main effects just specified as the focus of attention. Table 2 presents the mean scores for the causal attribution items, semantic differential scales, and attraction scale, as well as the univariate F values and significance levels for the main effect of achievement level obtained from these analyses.

Table 2 shows that subjects attributed the high achiever's performance more to ability, effort, and to friendly teachers and less to good luck in comparison with the average achiever's performance. They also saw the high achiever as having more positive qualities, as more introverted, and as more achievement-oriented when compared with the average achiever. All of these differences were statistically significant. Note, however, that although the total positive qualities score was significantly higher for the high achiever, scores on two components of this scale (sociable, good mixer) were significantly lower than for the average achiever. Thus, the picture of the high achiever that emerged from this analysis was that of an ambitious and positively regarded person who was more reserved and less sociable than the average achiever. Mean attraction scores were almost identical for the high and average achiever. Thus, these results show that the high achiever was perceived as a different kind of person when compared with the average achiever, but not necessarily as someone who was disliked.

Gender differences. The univariate analyses of variance provided two statistically significant main effects of gender of subject (only differences significant at the

Table 2 Mean Scores for Causal Attributions, Semantic Differential Scales, and Attraction for High Achiever and Average Achiever Before Failure.

Variable	Midpoint of scale	Mean scores: High achiever	Mean scores: Average achiever	*df*	*F*
Causal attributions					
Ability	4	5.02	4.19	1,514	49.34***
Effort	4	6.12	5.02	1,517	96.34***
Easy task	4	3.17	3.34	1,514	1.14
Good luck	4	2.07	2.57	1,518	15.44***
Friendly teachers	4	3.57	3.28	1,516	5.05*
Semantic differential					
Positive qualities	32	39.19	37.54	1,494	6.50*
Introversion	24	28.97	26.53	1,492	30.92***
Achievement orientation	32	39.02	34.25	1,480	70.93***
Attraction	28	28.69	28.63	1,509	.10

Note. $N = 348$ for high achiever; $N = 183$ for average achiever. Minor variations from these *N*s occurred because of missing cases.
* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

.01 or .001 levels are reported): Male subjects assigned more importance than female subjects to helpful teachers as a cause of the stimulus person's performance, $F(1,516) = 13.32$, $p < .001$; female subjects had higher attraction scores relating to the stimulus person when compared with the male subjects, $F(1,509) = 10.30$, $p < .001$.

Effects of fall. The set of variables assessed after the fall was analysed by using multivariate 2 x 2 x 3 analysis of variance (MANOVA) with gender of subject (male, female) as the first factor, gender of stimulus person (John, Anne) as the second factor, and type of fall (high to middle, high to bottom, middle to bottom) as the third factor in the analysis. The multivariate *F* was statistically significant for the main effect of gender of subject, $F(9,490) = 3.84$, $p < .001$; for gender of stimulus person, $F(9,490) = 2.98$, $p < .01$; and for type of fall, $F(18,980) = 3.16$, $p < .001$; but not for any of the other effects. Subsequently univariate 2 x 2 x 3 analyses of variance (ANOVAs) were computed for each variable to examine the three main effects just specified. Table 2 presents the mean scores for the causal attribution ratings, deserve to fall scores, respondent satisfaction scores, cue satisfaction scores, and more friendly attitude scores, as well as the univariate *F* values and significance levels for the main effect of type of fall.

Table 3 shows no statistically significant effects for type of fall when the causal attribution ratings and deserve to fall scores were analysed. The results indicate, however, that subjects saw lack of effort and a difficult examination as the most important causes of the stimulus person's fall. A statistically significant effect was obtained for cue satisfaction. John and Anne were seen as very displeased with their fall in all conditions (ratings were well below the neutral point on the scale), but especially when the fall was from top to bottom. Thus the stimulus person was perceived as less pleased with a large fall than with a smaller fall, a finding that indicates that the experimental manipulation of fall was successful.

Table 3 Mean Scores for Causal Attributions and Other Post-Fall Variables in Relation to Type of Fall

Variable	Midpoint of scale	Mean Scores: High to middle	High to bottom	Middle to bottom	*df*	*F*
Causal attributions						
Lack of ability	4	3.48	3.49	3.72	2,512	1.40
Lack of effort	4	5.10	5.04	5.01	2,514	.06
Difficult task	4	4.57	4.77	4.42	2,514	1.87
Bad luck	4	2.62	2.73	2.85	2,513	.86
Unfriendly teachers	4	3.02	2.88	3.18	2,513	.94
Deserve to fall	4	4.34	4.05	4.31	2,509	1.91
Respondent satisfaction	4	3.57	3.16	2.78	2,511	11.38***
Cue satisfaction	4	1.72	1.33	1.66	2,513	6.49**
More friendly attitude	2	2.16	2.12	2.04	2,506	3.40*

Note. $N = 175$ for high to middle fall; $N = 173$ for high to bottom fall; $N = 183$ for middle to bottom fall. Minor variations from these *N*s occurred because of missing cases.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Of greater interest are the statistically significant effects of type of fall that were obtained for respondent satisfaction and for more friendly attitude. In regard to the first variable, subjects in general provided ratings that were below the neutral point on the scale, but they expressed least displeasure about the fall when the stimulus person fell from high to middle and most displeasure when the fall occurred from middle to bottom. Similarly, in regard to the second variable, the most friendly attitudes were expressed towards the stimulus person when the fall was from high to middle and the least friendly attitudes when it was from middle to bottom.

More specific comparisons that involved respondent satisfaction with the fall showed that subjects were more pleased when the stimulus person fell from high to middle than from high to bottom, t (342) = 2.05, $p < .05$; more pleased when the fall was from high to bottom than from middle to bottom, t (351) = 2.33, $p < .05$; and more pleased when the fall was from high to middle than from middle to bottom, t (353) = 4.43, $p < .001$. These results are consistent with Hypothesis 2 and Hypothesis 3. Note that they show that the middle position was favoured by subjects when the stimulus person suffered a fall in that a fall to the middle position was more attractive in the relative sense than the other types of fall. Subjects also felt more friendly toward the stimulus person when the fall was from high to middle than from middle to bottom, t (350) = 2.63, $p < .01$, but the other comparisons that involved more friendly attitude were not statistically significant. Note that for both of these dependent variables (respondent satisfaction, more friendly attitude) the largest mean positive differences were found when the fall from high to middle was compared with the fall from middle to bottom.

Gender differences. The univariate analyses of variance provided three statistically significant main effects of gender of subject (only differences significant at the .01 or .001 levels are reported): Male subjects were more likely to attribute the fall to unfriendly teachers, F (1,513) = 7.50, $p < .01$; to feel more pleased about

the fall, $F(1,511) = 11.64$, $p < .001$; and to judge the stimulus person as more pleased with the fall, $F(1,513) = 7.12$, $p < .01$, when compared with female subjects. There was one statistically significant main effect of gender of stimulus person: Anne's fall was seen as more likely to be due to lack of ability when compared with John's fall, $F(1,512) = 16.18$, $p < .001$.

Attraction. The correlations between attraction to the stimulus person and the extent to which subjects reported feeling pleased about the fall were consistently negative for all three types of fall. The product moment correlations were as follows: high to middle fall, $r(170) = -.42$, $p < .001$; high to bottom fall, $r(163) = -.38$, $p < .001$; middle to bottom fall, $r(179) = -.31$, $p < .001$. Thus, in each case, the more subjects were attracted to the stimulus person, the less pleased they were about the fall. These results occurred irrespective of whether the stimulus person was a high achiever or an average achiever and they are consistent with Hypothesis 4. The 2 x 2 x 3 univariate analyses of variance of the effects of the fall that were described previously were re-run with attraction to the stimulus person as the covariate but there was no change to the pattern of statistically significant effects reported in Table 3.

Discussion

The results that relate to the fall of the high achiever are consistent with the hypotheses concerning the fall. Subjects were relatively more pleased (or less unhappy) when the high achiever failed than when the average achiever failed. They were also relatively more pleased (or less unhappy) when the failure took the high achiever to the middle of the performance scale than to the bottom of the performance scale. The more subjects were attracted to the stimulus person (high or average performer), the less pleased they reported they felt about that person's fall. The pattern of results is also consistent with a theoretical analysis that emphasises the effects of collectivist values. Falling to the average position in the middle of the scale was the least aversive outcome and falling away from the middle of the scale was the most aversive outcome in terms of how pleased the subjects were about the fall and how friendly they felt they would be towards the stimulus person after the fall. The middle or average position may be taken as the group norm, the position that represents the collectivity.

Note, however, that there was no evidence that subjects were initially more negative towards the high achiever when compared with the average achiever. Subjects perceived the high achiever as different in various ways from the average achiever but mean attraction scores for both stimulus persons were similar. The fact that mean scores were similar, however, does not necessarily imply an absence of mixed or ambivalent feelings towards the high achiever (or towards the average achiever for that matter). We may need to ask more subtle questions to uncover mixed feelings towards a high achiever, questions that relate to such emotions as envy and hostility. In this regard, it is relevant to note Foster's (1972) observation that people fear the consequences of envy and that envy is therefore often denied, appearing in muted or disguised forms. It may be easier to observe negative feelings towards high achievers when there is a clear pretext for expressing them, as when a high achiever suffers a fall. The present findings did support hypotheses when this kind of pretext was available, that is, when the high achiever fell from grace.

The effects of a fall found in Study 1 deserve investigation in other cultures where there may be a different balance in regard to collectivist and achievement values (Hofstede, 1980; Triandis, Bontempo, Villareal, Asai, & Lucca, 1988). It is interesting to note that in Japan, where collectivist values are important (Mann,

1986), there is a proverb that states that "The nail that sticks out is the one that gets pounded down." Whether one would find similar effects in North America, where there is a lot of emphasis on individualism and achievement, is a question for future research.

Study 2

The second study was also concerned with a high achiever and an average achiever who suffered a fall, but the nature of the fall was different. Whereas in Study 1 the fall was the result of failure at an examination, in Study 2 the fall was the outcome of a misdemeanour (cheating at an examination). The question to be answered was whether a fall that is the outcome of a misdemeanour or transgression has the same effects as a fall that is the result of a failure. The main hypothesis that was tested was that subjects will report being more punitive in their actions toward a transgressor when the misdemeanour is committed by a high achiever than by an average achiever and more pleased about the high achiever's fall.

There are a number of arguments that can be presented to support this hypothesis. In the first place, information that a high achiever has cheated may change one's perception of the high achiever and the way one attributes causality for that person's high achievement. Thus, an observer may conclude that the high achievement could have been due to cheating in the past and that any privileges that the high achiever may have obtained from his or her high achievement were unjustly earned.[2] Considerations of justice and equity would demand that the high achiever "pay the piper" and be punished more than the average achiever who cheated (cf. Lerner, 1980). Second, it can be argued that a lot of people believe that the achievement of high status carries with it the responsibility of setting a good example to others, though some idiosyncracies may be allowed (Hollander, 1964). When high achievers transgress they have violated normative expectations about appropriate behaviour from a high status person and therefore deserve greater penalties than those who have not achieved high status. Third, it may be the case that a transgression such as cheating provides an opportunity for observers to cut the high achiever down to size, making the high achiever more like the average person. This latter interpretation corresponds to the value analysis presented in relation to Study 1 but it generalises this analysis to a fall produced by a transgression rather than a failure.

It should be clear that I am acknowledging that the underlying processes involved in how people react to a fall produced by a transgression may differ from those involved in how they react to a fall produced by a failure. Study 2 was not designed to look closely at these underlying processes but rather to clarify whether attitudes toward the fall of a tall poppy show some generality despite a difference in the type of fall.

Method

Subjects

Three hundred and sixty-one subjects participated in the study (118 males, 243 females). These subjects were enrolled in an introductory psychology class at Flinders University in 1987. Mean age was 22.82 (SD = 7.42).

Overview of Procedure

The procedure was similar to that used in Study 1. Subjects completed a questionnaire during one of their regular class periods. Each questionnaire presented subjects with a hypothetical scenario that described a person who was either a high or average achiever on university examinations. Subjects then rated the stimulus person on the same 26 semantic differential scales that were used in Study 1 and answered the same questions about social interaction, perceived commonality, and liking as in Study 1. However, measures of causal attribution for the high or average performance were not included in the Study 2 questionnaire. Subsequently, the high achiever or average achiever was described as cheating on a major examination and subjects then answered questions that concerned the actions they would take about the cheating and how they would privately feel.

Four scenarios were employed that were derived from the 2 x 2 combination of the gender of the stimulus person (John, Anne) described in the scenario and whether the stimulus person was a high achiever or an average achiever. There were four forms of the questionnaire that corresponded to each of the four scenarios. The four forms of the questionnaire were randomly distributed to subjects in approximately equal numbers.

Scenarios. Each questionnaire began by introducing a student who was either a high achiever or an average achiever. The description of the high achiever or tall poppy was as follows:

> John (Anne) is a university student whose grades are consistently very high compared with others. In fact, John (Anne) receives As or distinctions in his (her) coursework and exams and he (she) is usually either top of the class or very close to top.

The description for the average achiever indicated that:

> John (Anne) is a university student whose grades are generally average. In fact, John (Anne) receives Cs or passes in most of his (her) coursework and exams and his (her) results are like those of most others in his (her) class.

Semantic differential. The matrix of intercorrelations between subjects' ratings of the stimulus person on the 26 semantic differential items was factor analysed, using the same procedure as in Study 1. Four factors were extracted that accounted for 41.1% of the variance. The fourth factor was again discarded for the same reasons as in Study 1. Three scales were constructed that were based on the first three rotated factors, involving items with factor loadings greater than .30. These scales were very similar to those obtained in Study 1 and they were given the same names. The items in each scale were as follows (the adjective in italics indicates the direction in which the item was scored, scores from 1 to 7 being assigned after reversal of the scores for items with negative factor loadings):

Positive qualities. This scale consisted of eight items (the factor loadings for each item are presented in parentheses): solitary-*good mixer* (.65), *sociable*-unsociable (-.63), unfriendly-*friendly* (.57), *warm*-cold (-.51), *wide interests*-narrow interests (-.49), unhelpful-*helpful* (.49), *attractive*-unattractive (-.47), and unpleasant-*pleasant* (.39). Total scores for positive qualities could range from 8 to 56. The internal reliability of the scale (alpha) was .76.

Introversion. This scale consisted of six items: hard-*soft* (.56), dishonest-*honest* (.48), boastful-*shy* (.46), unfair-*fair* (.46), tough-*tender* (.43), and conceited-*bashful* (.40). Total introversion scores could range from 6 to 42. The internal reliability of the scale (alpha) was .62.

Achievement orientation. This scale consisted of eight items: lacks ambition-*ambitious* (.83), uncompetitive-*competitive* (.72), *efficient*-inefficient (-.68), *confident*-unconfident (-.59), inferior-*superior* (.54), submissive-*dominant* (.51), weak-*strong* (.48), and passive-*active* (.43). Total achievement orientation scores could range from 8 to 56. The internal reliability of the scale (alpha) was .82.

Attraction. The matrix of intercorrelations between subjects' responses to the seven items concerned with social interaction, perceived commonality, and liking was factor analysed, using the same procedure as in Study 1. A single-factor solution was again found to be appropriate. The single factor accounted for 51.2% of the variance. The respective factor loadings for the seven items were .79, .83, .72, .60, .74, .56, and .74. The seven items were used to construct a scale called *attraction.* Total attraction scores could range from 7 to 49. The internal reliability of the scale (alpha) was .87.

The misdemeanour. Subjects were next presented with information that they were sitting a major examination with the stimulus person. Subjects were reminded in the scenario that their stimulus person was either a high achiever (consistent As, usually top of class) or an average achiever (consistent Cs, grades like those of most others in the class) and they were told that during the examination they became aware that the stimulus person was cheating.

Dependent variables. Subjects then answered questions about how they would react to the discovery that their stimulus person had cheated. The first question asked how likely it was that they would report the stimulus person to the authorities. The second question asked how likely it was that they would discuss the stimulus person's cheating with their fellow students. The anchors on the 1 to 7 rating scale used for each question were "very unlikely" (coded 1) and "very likely" (coded 7). The first variable is called *report to authorities* and the second variable is called *discuss with others.* The third question asked subjects to assume that the stimulus person was observed cheating by a person in authority. They were then asked how they would privately feel that the stimulus person had been caught cheating. The anchors on the 1 to 7 rating scale were "not at all pleased" (coded 1) and "very pleased" (coded 7). This variable is called *pleased about discovery.*

The final three questions were prefaced by a new development in the scenario in which subjects were asked to assume that they were on a disciplinary committee and had the task of presenting recommendations about what disciplinary actions the committee should take in regard to the stimulus person's cheating. They were asked to recommend one course of action from a list of six possible actions: no penalty (coded 1), severe reprimand (2), fail exam (3), fail course (4), temporary expulsion from the university (5), and permanent expulsion from the university (6). They were then asked to assume that the stimulus person had been expelled from the university for cheating and to indicate to what extent they thought that the stimulus person deserved this penalty. The anchors on the 1 to 7 rating scale were "John (Anne) didn't deserve what he (she) got" (coded 1) and "John (Anne) got what he (she) deserved" (coded 7). This variable is called *deserve penalty.* Finally, subjects were asked how they would privately feel about the stimulus person's expulsion. The anchors on the 1 to 7 rating scale were "not at all pleased" (coded 1) and "very pleased" (coded 7). This variable is called *pleased about expulsion.*

Results

High versus average achiever. The set of variables assessed before subjects received information about the cheating was analysed by using multivariate 2 x 2 x 2

analysis of variance (MANOVA) with gender of subject (male, female) as the first factor, gender of stimulus person (John, Anne) as the second factor, and achievement level (high, average) as the third factor in the analysis. The multivariate F was statistically significant for the main effect of achievement level, $F(4,321) = 80.09$, $p < .001$; and for the main effect of gender of stimulus person, $F(4,321) = 2.75$, $p < .05$; but not for any of the other effects. Subsequently, univariate 2 x 2 x 2 analyses of variance (ANOVAs) were computed for each variable to examine these main effects. Table 4 presents the mean scores on these variables as well as the univariate F values and significance levels for the main effects of achievement level obtained from the analysis.

Table 4 Mean Scores for Semantic Differential Scales and Attraction for High Achiever and Average Achiever Before Discovery of Cheating

Variable	Midpoint of scale	Mean scores: High achiever	Mean scores: Average achiever	*df*	*F*
Semantic differential					
Positive qualities	32	32.95	36.55	1,327	41.18***
Introversion	24	26.15	26.50	1,327	.81
Achievement orientation	32	41.11	32.12	1,327	238.37***
Attraction	28	30.15	30.87	1,334	.99

Note. $N = 361$. Minor variations from this N occurred for some of the items due to missing cases.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Table 4 shows that the stimulus person who was described as a high achiever was seen as having fewer positive qualities and as being more achievement-oriented than the average achiever. These two main effects of achievement level were highly significant. As was the case in Study 1, the high achiever was seen as less sociable and less of a good mixer than the average achiever. Table 4 also indicates that, as in Study 1, mean attraction scores were very similar for the high and average achiever. Mean attraction scores were higher for Anne than for John, $F(1,334) = 5.30$, $p < .05$.

Effects of cheating. The set of variables assessed after the cheating was also analysed by using the multivariate 2 x 2 x 2 analysis of variance (MANOVA) described previously. The multivariate F was statistically significant for the main effect of gender of stimulus person, $F(6,344) = 2.89$, $p < .001$; for the main effect of achievement level, $F(6,344) = 5.77$, $p < .001$; and for the interaction effect involving achievement level and gender of stimulus person, $F(6,344) = 5.60$, $p < .001$; but not for any of the other effects. Table 5 presents the mean scores on the six dependent variables as well as the univariate F values and significance levels for the main effects of achievement level.

The results in Table 5 show that subjects reported feeling significantly more pleased when the high achiever was caught cheating than when the average achiever was caught and also more pleased when the high achiever was expelled from the university because of cheating than when the average achiever was expelled. Note that the means were above the neutral point (4) on the 1 to 7 scale for feeling pleased about the discovery, that is, towards the happy end of the scale, but below the mean for feeling pleased about the expulsion, that is, towards the unhappy end of the scale.

Table 5 Mean Scores on Post-Cheating Dependent Variables for High Achiever and Average Achiever

Variable	Midpoint of scale	Mean scores: High achiever	Mean scores: Average achiever	*df*	*F*
Report to authorities	4	2.86	2.09	1,351	16.06***
Discuss with others	4	4.64	4.42	1,353	1.20
Pleased about discovery	4	4.81	4.33	1,353	7.96**
Penalty for cheating	3.5	3.32	3.04	1,352	9.41**
Deserve penalty	4	4.17	3.46	1,352	15.98***
Pleased about expulsion	4	3.52	2.93	1,351	19.40***

Note. $N = 361$. Minor variations from this N occurred because of missing cases.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Subjects also reported that they would be more likely to report the high achiever to the authorities, that they would award a stiffer penalty to the high achiever for cheating, and that they considered the high achiever deserved the penalty more when compared with the average achiever. These three main effects of achievement level were statistically significant. Note that the means were below the neutral point for the report to authorities variable, that is, towards the unlikely end of the scale; the mean for the penalty variable was close to three, that is, corresponding to fail the exam; and the mean for the deserve penalty variable was slightly above the neutral point for the high achiever, but below the neutral point for the average achiever.

Gender differences. The univariate analyses of variance provided one statistically significant main effect involving gender of stimulus person (only differences significant at the .01 or .001 levels are reported): John was more likely to be reported to the authorities than Anne, $F(1,351) = 7.95$, $p < .01$. There was also a significant interaction effect involving achievement level and gender of stimulus person: The penalty for the high achiever was stiffer when John was caught cheating than when Anne was caught but the penalty for the average achiever was stiffer when Anne was caught than when John was caught, $F(1,352) = 20.31$, $p < .001$.

Attraction. As in Study 1, significant negative correlations were obtained between attraction to the stimulus person and reported feelings of pleasure. The product moment correlations were as follows: for pleased about the discovery, r (340) = -.27, $p < .001$; for pleased about the expulsion, r (339) = -.26, $p < .001$. Thus, the more subjects were initially attracted to the stimulus person, the less pleased they were that the stimulus person was caught cheating or expelled from the university for cheating. These results occurred irrespective of whether the stimulus person was a high achiever or an average achiever. The correlation between the two measures of reported feelings was $r(357) = .50$, $p < .001$. The univariate 2 x 2 x 2 analyses of variance for the six dependent variables listed in Table 5 were re-run with attraction to the stimulus person as the covariate, but there was no change to the pattern of statistically significant effects reported in Table 5.

Discussion

These results support the hypothesis that subjects will report being more punitive when a misdemeanour is committed by a high achiever or tall poppy than by an average achiever and that they will also report feeling more pleased about

the high achiever's fall. The results parallel those obtained in Study 1, especially in regard to subjects' reported affective reactions (feeling pleased about the fall) and also in regard to the negative correlations found in both studies between attraction to the stimulus person and these reported affective reactions.

However, there were some differences in the results of the two studies. The mean score on the positive qualities scale for the high achiever was significantly lower in Study 2 than for the average achiever but significantly higher in Study 1 for the same comparison. Note, however, that in both studies the high achiever was seen as less sociable and more of a loner than the average achiever and more achievement-oriented. In Study 1 the high achiever was also seen as significantly more introverted but this difference on the introversion scale was not found in Study 2. These differences between studies may reflect the effects of sampling from different populations in different contexts (high-school students in Study 1; university students in Study 2), or the effects of other unknown variables.

In addition, subjects in Study 2 reported that the high achiever deserved to be punished more than the average achiever for cheating whereas, in Study 1, differences in deservingness did not occur in relation to the high or average achiever's failure. I indicated previously that Study 2 taps into a different type of situation when compared with Study 1. A transgression can trigger feelings that concern justice, equity, and retribution. When a high achiever commits a misdemeanour, subjects' perceptions of the high achiever and how he or she obtained their status can change. Subjects may also perceive that the mistake made by the high achiever is more serious and has wider consequences because the high achiever has acted irresponsibly and set a bad example to others. The deservingness variable may be especially sensitive to such effects in situations where misdemeanours occur. Subjects may be less likely to blame a consistently high achiever for an unexpected failure, however, depending on how they interpret the cause of the high achiever's failure. Moreover, the values that underlie the judgements made are more likely to be in the domain of competence and achievement than in the domain of morality.

Hence, it is important to recognise that different sets of underlying variables may have been involved in Study 1 and Study 2. At the same time, it is likely that the value analysis applied to the results of Study 1 is also relevant to interpreting the findings from Study 2. Thus, subjects may have reported feeling more pleased about the high achiever's fall in both studies because the fall cut the tall poppy down to size, showed that the tall poppy was fallible, and made the tall poppy more like others.

Finally, I would not want to claim that subjects' verbal statements about how they would punish the transgressor in Study 2 would correspond to how they would act in a real situation. Clearly, we need to move beyond subjects' responses to hypothetical scenarios to studies of the fall of tall poppies in actual situations.

Study 3

The two experimental studies so far described involved tall poppies who were high achievers, hypothetical scenarios concerned with academic achievement either at school or university, and subjects who were students. The bases for the fall of the high achiever (low grades in Study 1, cheating in Study 2) were also specified. The question arises as to whether the results of these two studies would generalise to other kinds of tall poppies, other contexts, other subject populations, and other types of fall. The third study to be described was designed to investigate attitudes toward tall poppies in general rather than just high achievers and the subjects who were tested were not students but came from the general population. The

study was also designed as a more direct test of an assumption underlying the two previous studies, namely that tall poppy attitudes are related to value preferences. It also investigated relations between tall poppy attitudes and levels of global self-esteem.

In the third study I constructed a scale that was designed to measure attitudes towards the tall poppy and then correlated scores on this scale with scores on a measure of self-esteem and with value priorities. Self-esteem was assessed by using a modified version of the Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale (Rosenberg, 1965). Value priorities were assessed by using an extension of the Rokeach Value Survey (Rokeach, 1973). A less direct measure of value priorities was also obtained by using information about subjects' political preference, on the assumption that those to the left in their political preference would be more likely to endorse collectivist values and less likely to endorse individualist values and authoritarian/conservative values when compared with those to the right in their political preference.

The first hypothesis tested in Study 3 was again based upon the assumption that the desire to bring down a tall poppy will be related to underlying values. I hypothesised that tall poppy attitudes would be related not only to collectivist values emphasising equality and group harmony and individualistic values emphasising ambition and achievement, but also to values concerned with social status and conformity to the status quo (Feather, 1979, 1984). One would expect that those who respect achievement, social status, and conformity would be more likely to favour a tall poppy, respecting the tall poppy's high position. Those who are more collectivist in their value preferences would be more likely to approve of a tall poppy's fall from grace and, given the opportunity, they may work to bring a tall poppy down.

The second hypothesis was suggested by theoretical analyses concerned with social comparison, relative deprivation, and frustration effects. Recent research on social comparison jealousy by Salovey and Rodin (1984) showed that subjects reported significantly greater jealousy or envy of another person when they were told that their standing on a self-relevant characteristic was worse than that of the successful other on the same characteristic.[3] Subjects also disparaged the successful other under these conditions and they were less likely to desire his or her friendship. They also tended to feel more depressed and anxious about interacting with the comparison person. Salovey and Rodin (1984) related their analysis to Silver and Sabini's (1978) assertion that social comparison envy will result when the possessions, attributes, and attainments of one person have the effect of diminishing the status of another person (see also Bers & Rodin, 1984; Sabini & Silver, 1982). They also noted the similarity between their analysis of social comparison jealousy and Tesser's model of self-evaluation maintenance (Tesser, 1986). This model also involves a consideration of the effects of social comparison along relevant or non-relevant attributes but does so in the context where the other is a close associate of the person. The "pain of comparison" occurs when unfavourable comparisons are made with others on self-relevant dimensions and where positive self-evaluation is under threat (Tesser & Campbell, 1983). These various approaches imply that a person will experience envy or jealousy about the superior achievement of a tall poppy and will denigrate the tall poppy in various ways when the achievement is relevant to the person and when the tall poppy is similar to the person in various respects or a close associate.

It will be observed that these forms of analysis set fairly specific conditions for the occurrence of social comparison jealousy or envy. A related approach is relative deprivation theory which also specifies conditions under which a person

feels deprived and experiences feelings of resentment, injustice, and anger that may be reflected in overt action. (Cook et al., 1977; Walker & Pettigrew, 1984). For example, Cook et al. (1977) assume that relative deprivation occurs when a person does not possess or have enough of an object, wants the object, compares self with others who have the object, and feels that it is feasible to obtain the object. They also assume that outcomes such as anger, resentment, and perceptions of unfairness will occur when the person feels entitled to the object that he or she lacks and does not feel personally responsible for not possessing the object - see also Weiner's (1986) recent discussion of emotions from an attributional perspective. This line of theorising could also be applied to the present context but also under special conditions.

My approach in Study 3 was less specific than those that I have just described. I hypothesised that subjects low in self-esteem would perceive themselves as more inferior to tall poppies than those high in self-esteem and would tend to denigrate them more. This simple hypothesis does not take account of the other variables identified in social comparison theory and relative deprivation theory (e.g., self-relevant attributes, feelings of entitlement) but it does involve the notion of discrepancy in status. The hypothesis can also be defended from another perspective. It can be argued that attitudes towards the tall poppy will reflect the amount of failure and frustration that individuals have experienced in their lives. Disappointment and anger about not achieving goals and not moving up the ladder of success may be displaced on those who have been successful and have achieved high status. Feeling pleased about a tall poppy's fall may then be linked to an individual's frustrated ambitions. If one assumes that consistent failure to achieve important goals determines lower self-esteem, then it would also be expected that individuals with low self-esteem would be happier to see a tall poppy fall than individuals with high self-esteem. The latter individuals may be more likely to identify with the tall poppy. The fall of a tall poppy may also be welcomed by a person with low self-esteem because the fall brings the tall poppy down to the level of the low self-esteem person. The low self-esteem person thereby becomes more similar to the hitherto successful tall poppy and, by association, may experience a boost in self-esteem.

Method

Subjects

Two hundred and five subjects were involved in the study (104 males, 101 females). These subjects were sampled from the general population of metropolitan Adelaide, South Australia. Mean age was 33.08 years (SD = 12.07).

Overview of Procedure. Subjects completed a questionnaire that contained a specially designed attitude scale (hereafter called the Tall Poppy Scale), the measures of value priorities and self-esteem, and a section concerned with demographic and background information (e.g., gender, age, political preference).

Tall Poppy Scale. The Tall Poppy Scale is presented in Table 6. It consists of 20 items, half of which express positive attitudes towards the tall poppy and half of which express negative attitudes. Subjects answered each item by using a 6-point scale labelled as follows: +1, I agree a little; +2, I agree on the whole; +3, I agree very much; -1, I disagree a little; -2, I disagree on the whole; -3, I disagree very much. A constant of 4 was subsequently added to item responses so as to obtain a positive scale.

Table 6 Items in Tall Poppy Scale and Factor Loadings following Varimax Rotation

Item		*Factors* I Favour Fall	II Favour Reward
1.	People who are very successful deserve all the rewards they get for their achievements	–	.58
2.	It's good to see very successful people fail occasionally	.52	–
3.	Very successful people often get too big for their boots	.58	–
4.	People who are very successful in what they do are usually friendly and helpful to others	–	.45
5.	At school it's probably better for students to be near the middle of the class than the very top student.	.38	–
6.	People shouldn't criticise or knock the very successful	–	.37
7.	Very successful people who fall from the top usually deserve their fall from grace	.63	–
8.	Those who are very successful ought to come down off their pedestals and be like other people	.69	–
9.	The very successful person should receive public recognition for his/her accomplishments	–	.44
10.	People who are "tall poppies" should be cut down to size	.66	–
11.	One should always respect the person at the top	–	.65
12.	One ought to be sympathetic to very successful people when they experience failure and fall from their very high positions	–	.37
13.	Very successful people sometimes need to be brought back a peg or two, even if they have done nothing wrong	.66	–
14.	Society needs a lot of very high achievers	–	.51
15.	People who always do a lot better than others need to learn what it's like to fail	.57	–
16.	People who are right at the top usually deserve their high position	–	.68
17.	It's very important for society to support and encourage people who are very successful	–	.70
18.	People who are very successful get too full of their own importance	.70	–
19.	Very successful people usually succeed at the expense of other people	.59	–
20.	Very successful people who are at the top of their field are usually fun to be with	–	.53

Note. Only those factor loadings that exceeded .30 are recorded.

The item responses were intercorrelated and the matrix of product-moment correlations was factor-analysed using the principal factor solution with iterated communalities followed by varimax rotation. Inspection of the eigenvalues indicated that a two-factor solution was appropriate. Table 6 presents the factor loadings for these two factors. The amount of variance accounted for by these two factors was 35.1%.

The first factor involved the 10 items that expressed negative attitudes towards the tall poppy and that favoured the tall poppy's fall (e.g., "People who are very successful get too full of their own importance"; "Those who are very successful ought to come down off their pedestals and be like other people"). I call this factor *Favour Fall.* Total scores on the 10 items could range from 10 to 70. The internal reliability (alpha) was .85.

The second factor involved the remaining 10 items that expressed positive attitudes towards the tall poppy and that favoured rewarding the tall poppy (e.g., "It's important for society to support and encourage people who are very successful"; "People who are right at the top usually deserve their high position"). I call this factor *Favour Reward*. Total scores on the 10 items could range from 10 to 70. The internal reliability (alpha) was .80.

A total score was also computed after reverse coding scores on the favour reward subscale and then summing across all 20 items. The total score indicates generally negative attitudes towards the tall poppy (favouring the fall and not rewarding the tall poppy's success). It controls for acquiescence response set. I call this score *Total Attitude*. Scores on this variable could range from 20 to 140. The internal reliability (alpha) was .86.

Value Survey. Subjects were presented with two value lists that corresponded to the terminal and instrumental values from the Rokeach Value Survey (Rokeach, 1973), except that the lists were much longer (30 terminal values, 26 instrumental values) and some of Rokeach's values were either deleted or modified in the way they were presented.[4] Each value was accompanied by a short descriptive phrase and subjects were asked to use a rating scale numbered from -1 to 7 to rate how important that value was as "a guiding principle in your life." The rating scale was labelled as follows: -1 (opposed to my values), 0 (not important), 3 (important), 6 (very important), and 7 (of supreme importance).

Eleven subscales were constructed that involved particular combinations of the values and that represented different motivational domains (Schwartz & Bilsky, 1987, 1989). These subscales with the associated values were as follows: *Hedonism* (pleasure, enjoying life); *Achievement* (ambitious, influential, capable, intelligent, successful); *Social Power* (social power, wealth, social recognition, authority, preserving my public image); *Self-Direction* (freedom, creativity, independent, curious); *Stimulation* (an exciting life, a varied life, daring); *Maturity* (mature love, unity with nature, wisdom, a world of beauty, broadminded); *Prosocial* (equality, meaning in life, a world at peace, true friendship, social justice, protecting the environment, honest, helpful, forgiving); *Security* (social order, national security, reciprocation of favours, family security, moderate, healthy); *Restrictive Conformity* (politeness, self-discipline, honouring of parents and elders, obedient, clean); *Tradition Maintenance* (respect for tradition, humble, accepting my portion in life, devout); *Spiritual* (inner harmony, spiritual life). The internal reliabilities (alphas) for the subscales were .69 for Hedonism, .69 for Achievement, .76 for Social Power, .55 for Self-Direction, .74 for Stimulation, .68 for Maturity, .77 for Prosocial, .62 for Security, .74 for Restrictive Control, .51 for Tradition Maintenance, and .39 for Spiritual.

These groupings of values correspond to motivational domains, eight of which were previously listed by Schwartz and Bilsky (1987, 1989) in their discussion of the universal content and structure of human values. Subsequently, three new motivational domains have been added (Stimulation, Tradition Maintenance, Spiritual). The Schwartz and Bilsky (1987, 1989) classification of motivational domains derived from a theoretical consideration of basic requirements that were assumed to pre-exist in all individuals, namely to satisfy biological needs, to achieve coordinated social interaction, and to meet social institutional demands for group welfare and survival. In the present study, the values included in each motivational domain were those that were classified in the domain in at least 8 out of 11 studies spanning different cultures (S. H. Schwartz, personal communication) on the basis of smallest space analysis (Brown, 1985; Guttman, 1968). An exception

was the spiritual domain where the two values were classified in that domain in at least 6 of the 11 studies. The motivational domains can also be classified as serving individualistic or collectivist interests or a mixture of both (Schwartz & Bilsky, 1987). Hedonism, achievement, social power, self-direction, and stimulation values are assumed to serve individualistic interests; prosocial, restrictive conformity, and tradition maintenance values are assumed to serve collectivist interests; values in the remaining motivational domains are assumed to serve mixed interests.

Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale. Subjects completed a modified 10-item version of the Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale (RSE; Rosenberg, 1965). Each item on the RSE involves a statement (e.g., "I feel that I'm a person of worth, at least on an equal plane with others"; "I am a useful person to have around"). The scale provides a measure of global self-esteem. Subjects answered each item by checking one of five answers that related to how true they thought the item was for self, ranging from "Never true" (1), through "Sometimes true (3), to "Almost always true" (5). Total self-esteem scores could range from 10 to 50. The internal reliability (alpha) of the 10-item scale was .86.

Political preference. Subjects were asked, "Which of the following political parties comes closest to representing your views?" They could answer "Liberal Party," "National Party," "Labor Party," "Democrat Party," or "Other." The percentages of subjects selecting each alternative were as follows: Liberal, 28.3%; National, 1.5%; Labor, 33.3%; Democrat, 18.7%; Other, 18.2%. For purposes of the data analysis, the responses of subjects who preferred one or other of the two minority parties (National and Democrat) or who answered "Other" were excluded and contrasts were made between those who supported the Liberal Party (moderately right wing) and those who supported the Labor Party (moderately left wing), though neither party deviated a long way from centre in the policies it espoused. I assumed that subjects who preferred the Liberal Party would be more conservative and respectful of authority and would put more stress on individual enterprise and achievement in contrast to those who preferred the Labor Party. Supporters of the Labor Party were assumed to be more concerned with social welfare and with reducing inequalities between people. This assumption is consistent with the policy platforms of the two parties.

Results

Self-esteem. Table 7 presents the mean scores, standard deviations, and correlations for the favour fall and favour reward subscales of the Tall Poppy Scale and for the total attitude scale, the value subscales, gender, political preference, and global self-esteem.

The mean score for favour fall was just below the midpoint (40) of the scale and the mean score for favour reward was just above the midpoint. On the average, therefore, subjects' attitudes were close to the neutral point. Scores on the two subscales were negatively correlated (r = -.36). Thus, the more subjects supported rewarding the tall poppy, the less they favoured the tall poppy's fall.

As predicted, support for the fall of the tall poppy was linked with lower global self-esteem (r = -.31). Subjects with higher global self-esteem, however, were not more likely to favour rewarding the tall poppy when compared with those lower in global self-esteem (r = .06). Subjects with lower self-esteem scores also tended to have stronger negative attitudes towards the tall poppy, that is, larger total attitude scores on the Tall Poppy Scale (r = -.24). Female subjects were lower

Table 7 Mean Scores, Standard Deviations, and Correlations for Value Subscales, Favour Fall, Favour Reward, Total Attitude, Global Self-Esteem, Gender, and Political Preference

Variable	Mean	*SD*	Correlations					
			Favour fall	Favour reward	Total attitude	Gender	Political preference	Global self-esteem
Value subscale								
Hedonism	4.36	1.55	.16*	.09	.04	.03	.04	-.02
Achievement	4.22	1.10	-.19**	.40***	-.35***	-.04	-.21*	.14*
Social power	2.38	1.38	.02	.33***	-.18*	-.08	-.32***	-.07
Self-Direction	4.55	1.06	-.07	.03	-.06	.03	.15	.11
Stimulation	3.55	1.51	.12	.18*	-.02	-.04	-.08	-.03
Maturity	4.33	1.14	-.05	.04	-.05	.15*	.20*	.00
Prosocial	4.83	.94	-.05	.00	-.03	.21**	.25**	-.02
Security	4.12	1.03	.06	.11	-.02	.09	-.05	-.10
Restrictive conformity	4.07	1.25	.10	.22**	-.06	.16*	-.15	-.17*
Tradition maintenance	2.52	1.31	.19**	.08	.08	.10	.01	-.25***
Spiritual	4.08	1.64	-.11	.02	-.08	.21**	.22*	.07
Tall poppy variables								
Favour fall	38.02	11.95	–	-.36***	.85***	-.06	.21*	-.31***
Favour reward	44.82	10.52	-.36***	–	-.80***	.04	-.32***	.06
Total attitude	73.24	18.55	.85***	-.80***	–	-.06	.30***	-.24***
Gender	1.49	.50	-.06	.04	-.06	–	.04	-.16*
Political preference	1.54	.50	.21*	-.32***	.30***	.04	–	-.01
Global self-esteem	41.19	5.26	-.31***	.06	-.24***	-.16*	-.01	–

Note. $N = 205$ except for correlations involving political preference where $N = 122$. There were minor variations from these *N*s due to missing cases. Means for value subscales have been converted to the -1 to 7 scale. Political preference was coded as follows: Liberal Party = 1, Labor Party = 2. Gender was coded as follows: Male = 1, Female = 2. Tests of significance are two-tailed.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

in self-esteem when compared with male subjects (r = -.16). All of these correlations were statistically significant.

One of the values in the Value Survey that was rated for importance was self-respect. Consistent with the global self-esteem correlations just presented, the importance assigned to self-respect was negatively correlated with favour fall, $r(201)$ = -.19, $p < .01$; positively correlated with favour reward, $r(201)$= .11, *ns*; and negatively correlated with total attitude, $r(200)$ = -.19, $p < .01$.

I also examined the possibility that the favour fall and favour reward variables may be related to self-esteem in a curvilinear manner, given the fact that Helmreich et al. (1970) found a curvilinear relation between self-esteem and liking in their study of the effects of a pratfall or foolish mistake. This analysis was conducted by splitting the distribution of self-esteem scores into equal thirds and by comparing the means for favour fall and favour reward across the bottom, middle, and top levels of self-esteem. The respective means for favour fall across these three levels were 42.22, 36.86, and 34.93, $F(2,202)$ = 7.34, $p < .001$. The respective means for favour reward were 44.23, 44.70, and 45.51, $F(2,202)$ = .27, *ns*. Thus, there was no evidence of curvilinear relations.

Value subscales. The statistically significant correlations in Table 7 involving the favour fall variable show that subjects who were more in favour of the fall of the tall poppy assigned more importance to hedonistic values, more importance to values concerned with tradition maintenance, and less importance to achievement values when compared with subjects who were less in favour of the fall of the tall poppy. Note that tradition maintenance was negatively correlated with global self-esteem. The positive correlation between tradition maintenance and favour fall may therefore reflect the effects of low global self-esteem. In that sense the positive correlation is consistent with the negative correlation between global self-esteem and favour fall that was just described.

The statistically significant correlations involving the favour reward variable show that subjects who were more in favour of rewarding the tall poppy assigned more importance to achievement values, social power values, values concerned with stimulation, and values involving restrictive conformity, when compared with subjects who were less in favour of rewarding the tall poppy.

The statistically significant correlations involving the total attitude score show that subjects with stronger negative attitudes toward the tall poppy assigned less importance to achievement and social power values.

Political preference. The statistically significant correlations involving political preference in Table 7 show that subjects who expressed a preference for the more to the left Labor Party assigned higher importance to maturity values, prosocial values, and spiritual values when compared with those who preferred the more to the right Liberal Party. Labor Party supporters saw achievement values and social power values as less important for themselves when compared with Liberal Party supporters. These value differences are consistent with the assumption that subjects' political preferences will reflect different sets of value priorities.

Consistent with the value differences just described, Table 7 shows that Labor Party supporters were more likely to favour the tall poppy's fall (r = .21) and less likely to support rewarding the tall poppy (r = -.32) when compared with Liberal Party supporters.[5]

Gender. The statistically significant correlations involving gender in Table 7 show that female subjects assigned higher importance to the values from the maturity, prosocial, restrictive conformity, and spiritual domains when compared with male subjects. These gender differences are consistent with those found in

previous studies with the Rokeach Value Survey (e.g., Feather, 1987) and they will not be discussed further.

Discussion

The results of the third study support the two hypotheses, except that collectivist values of a prosocial kind were not related to tall poppy attitudes as one might have expected. Nevertheless, tall poppy attitudes were related to global self-esteem and to some of the value domains in the predicted direction, especially to values concerned with achievement and social power. Subjects with negative attitudes toward the tall poppy tended to have lower global self-esteem and they were less likely to see achievement and social power values as important when compared with subjects with positive attitudes toward the tall poppy. Other value domains (e.g., tradition maintenance, restrictive conformity) were also involved in statistically significant relations with tall poppy attitudes, depending on the measure of attitude that was used. Relations between attitudes toward the tall poppy and political preference were consistent with the value analysis. Finally, subjects who favoured rewarding the tall poppy also tended to be less in favour of the tall poppy's fall, a finding that is consistent with the attraction results in Study 1 and Study 2.

General Discussion

The three studies that I have described in this article open up new areas of investigation. They inform us about attitudes towards the high achiever and they advance our knowledge and understanding of how people react when a tall poppy falls and the psychological variables that might underlie the reactions. They go some way toward increasing our understanding of a relatively neglected area in psychology, namely the psychology of envy. I have not attempted to explain the research findings in terms of some universal theory. That could turn out to be a fruitless enterprise. At the present stage of inquiry it is more appropriate to examine tall poppy effects in different contexts, to look for common variables that might mediate these effects, and to be open to the possibility that different psychological processes may also be involved, depending on circumstances.

The research can be extended in various directions. It should be possible to test hypotheses using some of the theoretical approaches that I mentioned previously and to move beyond the use of hypothetical scenarios to the examination of real-life situations. For example, one could apply Tesser's (1986) model of self-evaluation maintenance to the tall poppy situation as it occurs in the classroom and take the actual examination performance of students into account. Would students with consistently high grades be more likely to bring down the tall poppy in the classroom than students whose grades tend to be average or low or would the reverse occur? According to Tesser's (1986) analysis the performance of the high achiever would be more relevant to the former students. They should therefore be more likely to engage in a comparison process by diminishing the performance of a high achiever who is a close associate. Alternatively, would students with high grades protect and support the high achiever because they see the high achiever as similar to themselves and would students with low grades try to disparage the tall poppy?

Following Foster's (1972) analysis of the anatomy of envy and related ideas from research on justice and attribution, are feelings towards a tall poppy more positive if the tall poppy's success is seen to be on the basis of fair competition

or otherwise deserved according to the rules? Is it the case, as Foster suggests, that individuals are reluctant to admit to feelings of envy except in muted or disguised ways because of their fear of the consequences of envy? If so, then negative feelings that express envy would probably be more likely to occur when the tall poppy falls from grace because one then has an excuse for criticism and condemnation.

Finally, to what extent do tall poppy effects vary across cultures and across groups within the same culture? And do these effects differ depending upon the area in which the tall poppy is eminent or excels (e.g., intellectual accomplishment, achievement in sport, success in business, or political eminence) or are they limited to some areas but not others? Would these differences relate to differences in cultural and social values along dimensions such as collectivism versus individualism or other value classifications? Might negative tall poppy attitudes be less apparent when a culture has pride in its achievements and does not suffer from a "cultural cringe"?

These and many other questions remain to be investigated. The topic is one that has significant general implications. The attitudes that people hold towards tall poppies may be an important ingredient that influences the stability and advancement of groups and societies. The indiscriminate lopping of tall poppies can be harmful to progress. While some tall poppies deserve to be brought down because of their mistakes, others need encouragement and support. The key question is to distinguish between the good tall poppies and the bad tall poppies. The answer to that question confronts one with decisions that require an understanding of wider human values and how values operate at individual and societal levels.

[1] The 1982 supplement to the *Oxford English Dictionary* defines "tall poppy" in Australia as "an especially well-paid, privileged, or distinguished person." The 1988 edition of the *Australian National Dictionary* defines a "tall poppy" as "a person who is conspicuously successful" and (frequently) as, "one whose distinction, rank, or wealth attracts envious notice or hostility" (Ramson, 1988). The origins of the term go back to ancient times. The Roman historian, Livy, refers to the symbolic decapitation of the heads of the tallest poppies by the elder Tarquinius when walking in his garden. This message was conveyed to his son, Sextus Tarquinius, who then rid himself of the chief men of the state of Gabii and thus delivered the state unresisting to the Roman king.

[2] The effects of the misdemeanour on perceptions and attributions would vary depending on the relevance of the misdemeanour to the tall poppy's high position. Information that the high achiever was fined for a speeding offence or caught shoplifting in a supermarket, for example, would not have the same implications for attributions concerning how the high achiever achieved his or her high position as would information that the high achiever cheated at an important examination. The latter information throws the causes of the high achievement into question.

[3] Salovey and Rodin (1984) do not distinguish between jealousy and envy but others have made this distinction. For example, Foster (1972) believes that, "Envy stems from the desire to acquire something possessed by another person, while jealousy is rooted in the fear of losing something already possessed" (p. 168).

[4] I am indebted to Shalom Schwartz for providing me with a copy of this extended version of the Value Survey as well as other information from cross-cultural studies.

[5] There was also a negative relation obtained between favour fall and the status or prestige of subjects' reported occupations, scaled from *low status* (1) to *high status* (7), on the basis of Congalton's (1969) classification. The correlation was $r(170) = -.28$, $p < .001$. Thus, subjects with lower status occupations were more likely to support the tall poppy's fall when compared with those with higher status occupations.

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